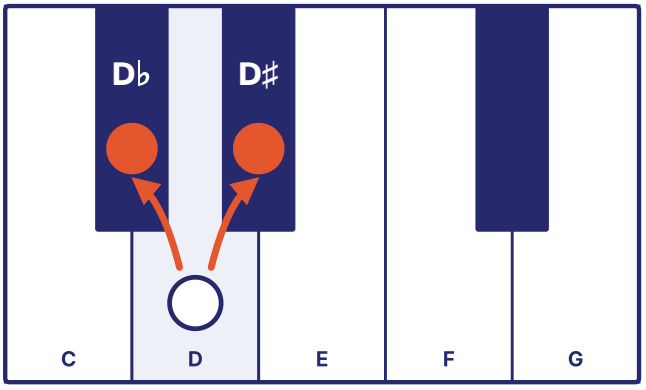
PART I · PITCH · 5

Sharps, flats and naturals

A sharp, flat or natural in front of a note (an **accidental**) nudges it, usually by a semitone. **Sharp**: one key right, usually black. **Flat**: one key left.

THE SECRET

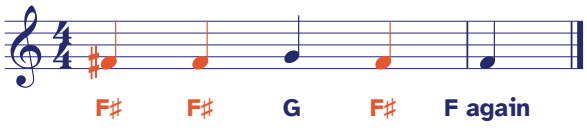
Sharp: the very next key to the right. Flat: the very next key to the left.



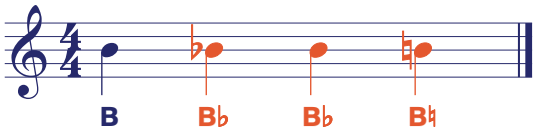
♯ one key right · ♭ one key left

SIGN	NAME	WHAT IT DOES	FIRST MET
♯	sharp	raises a note by a semitone	Level 0
♭	flat	lowers a note by a semitone	Level 0
♮	natural	cancels a sharp or flat	Level ½
𝄪	double sharp	raises by two semitones	Level 4
𝄫	double flat	lowers by two semitones	Level 4

Sharp till the bar line



The sharp still counts later in the bar; after the bar line, F is F again.



A natural cancels the flat for the rest of the bar.

Only that line or space. A sharp on the F in the first space does not change the F an octave higher.

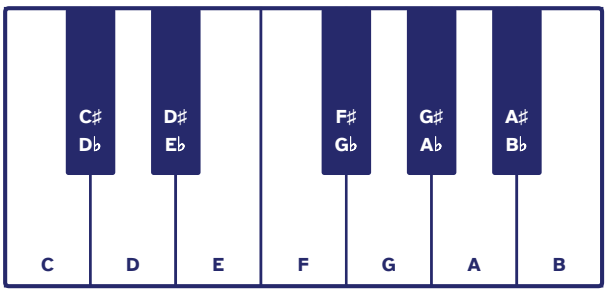
A tie carries it on. A note tied across the bar line keeps its accidental.

Reminders. A courtesy accidental, sometimes in brackets, just reminds you after a bar line.

PART I · PITCH · 5 · CONTINUED
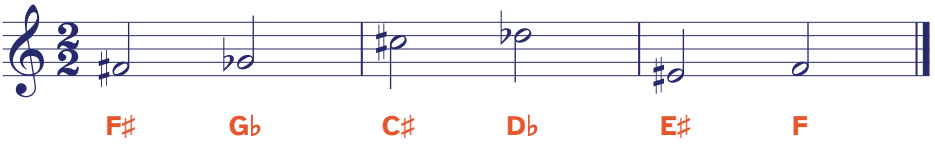
One key, two names

Every black key has two names: the key between F and G is both **F♯** and **G♭**. Notes that sound the same but are written differently are **enharmonic**. White keys can have sharp or flat names too: **E♯** is F, **C♭** is B.



EXAMPLE 1

One key, two names



1. **The first bar:** F♯, then G♭.
2. **Find them:** both are the black key between F and G.
3. **The last bar:** no black key sits above E, so E♯ is the white key F.

Same key, different names: these are **enharmonic** notes.

GAME

Which key is it?

1	2	3	4
C♯	E♭	B♯	F♭

Sharp: one key to the right. Flat: one key to the left. Which key do you press?

Answer: 1 the black key right of C · 2 the black key left of E · 3 the white key C · 4 the white key E.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS
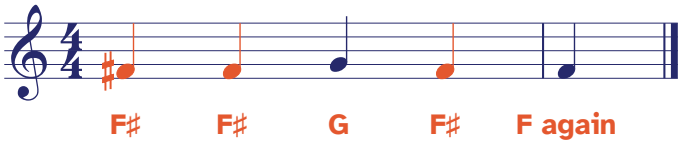


Play D, D♯, D♭.

D, then one key right (the black key), then one key left of D (another black key). Say the names as you play.

PART I · PITCH · 5 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

How long does the sharp last?

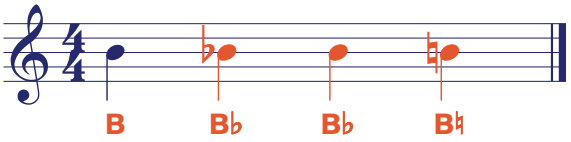


1. **The first note:** F♯.
2. **Later in the bar:** F is still F♯.
3. **After the bar line:** F is plain F again.

An accidental lasts **until the bar line**, then the key signature rules again.

EXAMPLE 3

A natural cancels the flat
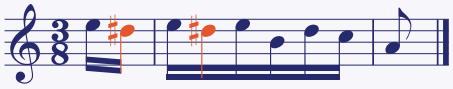


1. **B**: the white key.
2. **B♭**: one key to the left, and it stays flat for the rest of the bar.
3. **B♮**: the natural cancels the flat, back to the white key.

A natural **cancels** a sharp or flat until the bar line.

YOU KNOW THIS

Für Elise (Beethoven)



E, **D♯**, E, **D♯**: a semitone down and back. The sharp is written again in the new bar, because the bar line wiped it out.

Try it. Play E and D♯ back and forth: the black key just left of E.

THINK OF IT A key signature is the principal's notice on the school board: it speaks to every student, every day. An accidental is a teacher stopping at one student's desk: the message is for that note only, and it lasts until the next bar line.

TRAP

- × Forgetting that an accidental lasts until the bar line.
- × Carrying an accidental into the next bar: after the bar line, the key signature rules again.

SEE ALSO
Keys and key signatures p. 75

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Pitch 3 · Online: Library › Signs